

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 62

By Johnson

A RESOLUTION to commemorate the 100th anniversary of the murder of Constable Sam Locke of Williamson County.

WHEREAS, in Williamson County in the spring of 1925, an undertaker transporting a body to the cemetery noticed an unsettling scene: a car positioned near a gate with headlights on and door open; recognizing the vehicle to be that of Sam Locke, he stopped to investigate and found the owner of the vehicle lifeless on the ground with a bullet wound on his neck and another on his abdomen; and

WHEREAS, his life cut short at the age of forty-seven, Sam Locke was a lifelong Williamson Countian and was married to Beatrice Hendricks, with whom he had six children; he was a steward at the Methodist Church and respected throughout the community; and

WHEREAS, Constable Locke worked in local law enforcement until three months prior to his death, at which point he had become a prohibition officer, assisting federal officers in the discovery and destruction of illegal stills in Williamson County; in those three short months, he had aided in the destruction of seventy-three stills; and

WHEREAS, although Sam Locke was beloved and admired by some sects of local society, others in Williamson County held great disdain for him, including father-and-son alcohol purveyors "Papa" John Truett, Sr., and Neely Truett; and

WHEREAS, the Truetts owned a livery stable in Franklin, an establishment rife with alcohol and gambling; the stable housed a wholesale manufacturing center for alcohol and employed a number of people in the county as distributors; and

WHEREAS, it was alleged that Constable Locke had discovered that many county officials were cooperating with the Truett operation, being paid for their silence, and as he continued his investigation, the Truetts became increasingly vexed; and

WHEREAS, John and Neely Truett conspired to rid themselves of Sam Locke, enlisting a reluctant but eventually capitulating hitman in Jim Kelton; town whisperings led federal investigators to Mr. Kelton, who at first denied but later, under pressure, admitted to slaying Constable Locke; and

WHEREAS, although Sam Locke did not live to see the changes, his devoted work to root out and crack down on lawbreakers resulted in the arrest of Williamson County constables on bribery charges and an uprising in the community, with citizens demanding an end to the crime and lawlessness that plagued their county. The Truetts were also brought to justice for their illegal operations, only one year after the killing of Constable Locke; and

WHEREAS, Sam Locke is an important figure in the history of Williamson County, and much can be learned from his integrity and persistence in carrying out justice, even in the face of great peril; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Constable Sam Locke on the 100th anniversary of his murder, extolling him as a shining example of integrity and commitment to justice and acknowledging his place in the annals of Williamson County history.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.